

SCIENCE OF READING REVIEW: UNIVERSITY OF ARKANSAS - LITTLE ROCK

TRADITIONAL AND ALTERNATIVE

On-Site Review: February 27-29, 2024

WHAT'S IN THIS REPORT?

This report uses evidence from an on-site review to examine how an educator preparation program prepares candidates to teach reading using scientific reading instruction, as Arkansas requires of every approved program. It is meant to inform a continuous improvement process that takes educator preparation programs closer to the goals needed to serve Arkansas's students.

The on-site reviews are carried out by Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US), an external review organization. TPI-US teams inspect coursework and course materials, observe instruction and clinical practice, review program data, and hold focus groups with candidates, faculty, mentor teachers, and school partners. Division of Elementary and Secondary Education staff participate in the review.

TPI-US rates the program in the three review areas of the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

- Review Area 1, "Quality of Literacy Coursework," is rated from course materials, syllabi, assignments, and observations of instruction.
- Review Area 2, "Quality of Field-Based Experiences," is rated from placement records, observation and feedback evidence, and focus groups with candidates, mentor teachers, faculty, and school partners.
- Review Area 3, "Quality of Performance Management and Continuous Improvement," is rated from program data systems, quality-control checkpoints, monitoring practice, and partnership evidence.

Every review area receives a rating. Depending on the framework version, the report may also rate each criterion; some earlier reports discuss every criterion without stating a separate rating for it. Performance Levels are defined as follows, in language drawn from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

PERFORMANCE LEVEL	WHAT THE RATING MEANS
4 — EXCEEDS	Coursework and training CONSISTENTLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
3 — MEETS	Coursework and training USUALLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
2 — APPROACHING	Coursework and training INCONSISTENTLY address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.
1 — BELOW	Coursework and training RARELY OR DO NOT address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.

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REVIEW AREA PERFORMANCE LEVELS		
REVIEW AREA 1 LITERACY INSTRUCTION	REVIEW AREA 2 FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES	REVIEW AREA 3 PARTNERSHIPS
BELOW	APPROACHING	APPROACHING
CRITERIA REVIEWED		
CORRECTIVE ACTION STATUS		
Corrective action plan in place for this review cycle. This program is carrying out a corrective action plan with the Division covering fourteen actions.		

PROGRAM INFORMATION

INSTITUTION NAME	University of Arkansas - Little Rock
LOCATION	Little Rock, Arkansas
PROGRAM REVIEWED	Traditional and residency elementary education programs and the special education program
PATHWAY	Traditional and Alternative
REVIEW FRAMEWORK	TPI-US Arkansas Literacy Review Framework (2024)
REVIEWING BODY	Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US)
SITE VISIT DATES	February 27-29, 2024

REVIEW AREA 1: QUALITY OF LITERACY INSTRUCTION

REVIEW AREA 1 PERFORMANCE LEVEL
BELOW
CRITERION RATINGS
<i>This review states one rating for the review area and discusses the criteria in narrative. It does not state a separate rating for each criterion, so none is published here.</i>
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND
Reviewers examined ELEM 3301 and ELEM 4301 Integrated Language and Literacy I and II, READ 3322 Foundations of Reading, and SPED 4302 Language Development and Disorders. Use of Scarborough's Rope and the Simple View of Reading was inconsistent, and candidates lacked the content knowledge to teach with high-quality instructional materials or to evaluate and select them. No coursework in the three programs addressed concepts of print, and reviewers found no evidence of explicit fluency instruction or of writing instruction, despite a syllabus objective in ELEM 3301. Faculty emphasized vocabulary over oral language, could not articulate differences between READ 3322 and ELEM 3301, and taught comprehension only through vocabulary.
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS
• Build and spiral scientifically based reading content across residency, traditional, and special education programs • Have instructors label and model structured literacy components, extending practice into field experiences
CORRECTIVE ACTIONS TARGETING THIS AREA
Eight of the fourteen corrective actions target this review area.

REVIEW AREA 2: QUALITY OF FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES

REVIEW AREA 2 PERFORMANCE LEVEL
APPROACHING
CRITERION RATINGS
<i>This review states one rating for the review area and discusses the criteria in narrative. It does not state a separate rating for each criterion, so none is published here.</i>
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND
Reviewers found that the program had not yet checked whether placements were in high-performing or improving schools, though an interim placement coordinator who started in December 2023 began building those structures. The residency handbook set explicit mentor criteria, but selection differed across the residency, traditional, and special education programs, and interviewed mentors could not explain why they were chosen. Residency and traditional candidates practiced with high-quality instructional materials through ELEM 3301 and ELEM 4301, while special education candidates could finish without teaching reading. Because all literacy courses fell in one semester, candidates had no earlier literacy field teaching. Written feedback often omitted the concrete next steps that oral feedback supplied.
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS
• Provide two-days-a-week early field placements with content-expert feedback on applying the science of reading • Create field experiences for multilingual students and Tier 2 and Tier 3 instruction, with feedback aligned to the state evaluation rubric
CORRECTIVE ACTIONS TARGETING THIS AREA
Four of the fourteen corrective actions target this review area.

REVIEW AREA 3: QUALITY OF PARTNERSHIPS

REVIEW AREA 3 PERFORMANCE LEVEL
APPROACHING
CRITERION RATINGS
<i>This review states one rating for the review area and discusses the criteria in narrative. It does not state a separate rating for each criterion, so none is published here.</i>
WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND
Reviewers found that the program collected field experience data, problem of practice cycle data, walk-through data, course surveys, and mentor surveys, but that uneven evaluator training left the data not always accurate enough to guide improvement, and no single platform housed it. The residency program set performance gates tied to evaluation levels and growth plans, while the traditional and special education programs had no explicit checkpoints. Monthly faculty meetings run as a professional learning community used observation data, yet no formal structure monitored syllabus or instruction quality. Governance meetings with a partner district shared data and shaped professional development, though joint follow-up on affiliation agreements was absent and no written improvement plan covered all programs.
REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS
• Collect, check, and monitor accurate coursework and observation data, then use it to drive improvement • Develop a written improvement plan with goals, benchmarks, timelines, responsible parties, and accountability • Use the partnership personnel survey to evaluate partnerships and candidate learning with high-quality instructional materials
CORRECTIVE ACTIONS TARGETING THIS AREA
Two of the fourteen corrective actions target this review area.

CORRECTIVE ACTION PLAN

Where a review identifies findings that require follow-up, the program develops a corrective action plan with the Division of Elementary and Secondary Education. The recommendations under each review area above are the reviewers' advice; the plan below is the program's formal response, monitored by the Division. Actions are grouped by the review area whose findings prompted them.

TOTAL ACTIONS	HIGH PRIORITY	MEDIUM PRIORITY	LOW PRIORITY
14	11	3	0

The plan sets out 14 corrective actions: 11 high priority and 3 medium priority. The priorities are the plan's own.

ACTIONS THE PROGRAM IS TAKING

PRIORITY	ACTION	FINDING THAT REQUIRED IT	SUCCESS METRICS
HIGH RA1	Program-Wide SoR Spiral & Assessment Alignment	Instruction rated 1; need coherent spiral across residency/traditional/SPED with aligned assessments and multiple practice opportunities.	Published SoR scope/sequence; ≥90% courses show explicit SoR objectives, modeled practice, and aligned checks; assessment map completed.
HIGH RA1	Concepts of Print (COP) Instruction & Calibration	No evidence of COP instruction across programs; need explicit instruction and calibrated assessment.	100% candidates complete COP practice/assessment with feedback; IRR ≥0.80 for COP scoring.
HIGH RA1	Oral Language: Explicit Modeling & Application	Below expectations; limited evidence in phonology, morphology, syntax, bilingualism; need modeling and scaffolded practice.	OL modules embedded in methods; candidates complete ≥2 coached cycles applying OL strategies; rubric avg ≥3/4.
HIGH RA1	Phonological & Phonemic Awareness Deep Dive	Below expectations; limited depth and assessment variety; need knowledge + practice with multiple assessments.	Candidates implement ≥3 PA/phonemic routines with multiple assessments (e.g., segmentation, blending); rubric avg ≥3/4.
HIGH RA1	Phonics/Orthography/AWR Continuum & Transfer	Overlap in courses and unclear developmental continuum; need restructure for structural analysis and transfer.	New phonics/orthography sequence approved; candidates demonstrate mapping/decoding/encoding proficiency ≥80%.
MEDIUM RA1	Fluency Instruction & Assessment Toolkit	Minimal explicit instruction/assessment use; need deeper knowledge and data use.	Toolkit used in coursework/field; candidates administer & analyze fluency measures; rehearsal growth targets met.
MEDIUM RA1	Vocabulary & Comprehension Integration	Comprehension rated below; integrate explicit strategies (morphology, knowledge building, language structures) aligned to assessments.	Each methods course includes explicit V/C modules; ≥2 modeled mini-lessons; candidate units meet rubric ≥3/4.

PRIORITY	ACTION	FINDING THAT REQUIRED IT	SUCCESS METRICS
MEDIUM RA1	Writing Across the Literacy Block	Below expectations; lack of assignments linked to writing instruction; model recursive process and application.	Writing mini-lessons embedded; candidates complete a writing cycle (plan-teach-assess-revise) with rubric avg $\geq 3/4$.
HIGH RA2	Early & Sequenced Field Practice (FE1 to FE2)	Need earlier, staged field practice including Grades 3-6; intensive practice beyond late-semester block.	FE1 adds weekly practice; FE2 expands to small-group/whole-class; ≥ 2 graded rehearsals per component.
HIGH RA2	Mentor & Placement Criteria (Schools + Teachers)	Variability and lack of formalization; ensure HQIM/SoR modeling and coaching capacity.	Updated MOUs with school criteria; mentor rubric adopted program-wide; 100% mentors meet proficiency.
HIGH RA2	ML & Readers-with-Difficulties Application Cycles	Below expectations for ML and dyslexia-responsive practice; ensure intentional opportunities.	Each candidate completes ≥ 1 ML cycle and ≥ 2 Tier 1-2 intervention cycles; fidelity $\geq 80\%$; PM gains evident.
HIGH RA2	Observation/Feedback Calibration + IRR	Inconsistent written/oral feedback; need calibration and literacy-specific next steps.	IRR ≥ 0.80 among evaluators; feedback includes actionable literacy steps aligned to evidence.
HIGH RA3	Literacy Control Gates & Unified Data Platform	Data quality/usage variable; need literacy-specific gates and centralized access.	Gate criteria published; $\geq 90\%$ pass rate by final gate; dashboard live and reviewed each term to drive changes.
HIGH RA3	Program-Wide Written Improvement Plan	No unified plan across programs; need goals, benchmarks, timelines, owners, accountability.	Plan approved by governance; milestone tracker shows on-time completion $\geq 85\%$; quarterly progress reviews conducted.

OVERSIGHT

Each action in the plan carries an evidence requirement and a rationale tied to a review finding. The plan leaves the responsible owner and the completion timeline for program leadership to assign, so those entries are not recorded in the plan as issued and are not published here. Review area assignments in the table below were made by matching each action's stated rationale to the review area whose findings it answers. The Division separately issued a corrective action determination for this program, identifying 12 corrective actions of which 10 are required and 2 are recommended. The plan below is the program's response to that determination.

Sources: TPI-US Arkansas Literacy Review, University of Arkansas - Little Rock, February 27-29, 2024, conducted under the TPI-US Arkansas Literacy Review Framework (2024). University of Arkansas - Little Rock Science of Reading Corrective Action Plan, Arkansas DESE. Rating scale language quoted from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework.